

Help!



Often, during the life of your PC, there comes a time when you will throw up your hands and scream

talking about her debacle with Linux. Computers were never designed as a consumer product, but with e-mail and the Internet becoming a necessity, they have become an indispensable part of domestic life.

No other consumer product requires hands-on maintenance and support like the PC. Take hardware that goes obsolete sooner than Viva's latest single, a disreputable operating system, bug ridden software, driver updates, software patches, virus attacks, ISP problems, and you have a recipe for disaster. When consumers expect a computer to work like a toaster or a washing machine, there is bound to be computer rage. Computer rage is induced by a lot of things like problematic software and hardware, confusing interfaces, virus attacks, or just plain ignorance. "I've never been a whiz with computers. In

fact, they intimidate me. How am I supposed to know why my computer isn't taking printouts?" says Kavita Jayakumar, mentioning a recent glitch between her computer and printer.

Send for backup now!

So what do you do when your computer throws a tantrum you can't handle? Service support engineer Sampath Iyengar has a simple answer: "Call for technical support. If your PC is under warranty, use it. Most branded PCs carry a one to three-year warranty. All you have to do is contact your reseller and ask him to send a technician, or guide you on the phone. You can be assured that your computer will soon be in order."

Buying a branded PC does have certain benefits, like authorised service centers and system service providers in every major city. Compaq India has a support centre in Mumbai called 'Compaq

What do you do when your hard drive crashes and all your data is lost? Or when your machine reboots time and again for no apparent reason? Hitting your head on the wall is not going to help! The most frustrating situation is when your computer won't boot at all, leaving you completely helpless. Equally annoying are error messages you constantly run into during your computer's startup process.

Rage against the machine

There's a Civil War brewing between the technology literate and the illiterate, and the divide is only widening. "GUI might as well mean Ghee Under Iowa to my illiterate self; I haven't learnt any special *fundas* from some course!" chats Supriya Nair,

Before you Call in the Experts

- ✓ **Check the power supply:** Always check your cables and power plug. Most technical support calls are resolved with this simple reminder.
- ✓ **Record your error messages:** Keep a journal to write down the error message as you see it, complete with the special characters, etc. Accurate information highly increases your chances for a fast solution.
- ✓ **Record your actions when the problem occurred:** Think back to what you were attempting to do when your system stopped working. What may seem like trivial informa-

tion might turn out to be very significant for the technician.

✓ **Back up your entire system often:** One common solution to many a difficult situation is to reformat the hard drive by totally clearing it and reinstalling everything from scratch.

✓ **Store your program and driver disks in one place:** Keep all your original program CDs and floppies, including your original operating system disks, in an easily accessible place. If you have updated your system, copy each updated file on to its own labelled floppy disk and place it in the same box.